

Rhetorical analysis tips: cram sheet

AP English Language

Key ideas

1. Format: The words "X" indicate the strategy Y (Author page). No "of" after "strategy."
2. Thesis: writer, title and occasion, then the **purpose**, then the choices with what each does.
3. Analyze the language, never whether the writer is right: device, exact **key words**, effect on the audience, how it helps the purpose.
4. New RA assignments want devices you haven't used yet. On official RAs, any device works if it's **impactful** and matters.
5. Banned labels: ethos, pathos, logos, imagery, hyperbole, simile, personification, rhetorical question.

Format		every RA	Thesis		one sentence	
Step 1 line	The words "X" indicate the strategy Y (Author page). No "of."		Shape	writer, title and occasion, then the purpose, then the choices with what each does.		
Every strategy	Bold and numbered; key words, not full sentences.		Rules	third person, no contractions, no figurative language, source named first.		
Steps	Step 1 page by page; Steps 2 to 4 cover the whole piece.		Choices	named by what they do, never as appeals; they become the body paragraphs.		
Banned	ethos, pathos, logos, imagery, hyperbole, simile, personification, rhetorical question.		Complexity	name a shift, like humor first and the hard demand second.		
Also	No contractions, never "narrator" for a speech, page numbers from the printed handout.					
Step 4 test	Still works without the author's exact words? It's summary.					
Analyze		two reads	Hunt			higher-level devices
Read 1	the gist: who, to whom, when, why. Judge every choice against that purpose.		Which ones	new RA assignments: ones you haven't used; official RAs: any that's impactful and matters.		
Read 2	highlight 7 to 10 sentences that sound built rather than just said.		Look at	sentence edges, lists, short after long, punctuation, questions, flips, register drops, the opening and the close.		
Each device	device, key words, effect on the audience, how it helps the purpose.		Trade up	rhetorical question to hypophora or aporia; hyperbole to amplification or auxesis.		
Verbs	exposes, undercuts, reframes, concedes, deflates, compresses, indicts. Drop shows, uses.		Ten to hunt	diacope, epanorthosis, metonymy, anadiplosis, tricolon, auxesis, aposiopesis, synonymia, apophasis, zeugma.		
			Rule	a wrong fancy name is worse than a correct common one.		

Abbreviations: RA = rhetorical analysis; DFW = David Foster Wallace